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APPRENTICE

John Fitzgerald Kennedy cut an impressive figure on the cold Washington day of his inauguration, January 20, 1961. Tall and erect, despite his back problems, dressed in a tailcoat as everyone around him wore a winter coat, he projected youth, energy, optimism, and determination. The youngest person ever elected president of the United States—he was only forty-three years old—left no doubt by his looks and words that he was ready to chart a new course for his country and the world, not just for the duration of his presidency but for decades ahead.[1]

Leadership was passing from one generation to another, the transition captured by cameras as the gray, balding, and warmly dressed outgoing president, Dwight Eisenhower, accompanied his young successor to the ceremony in the same automobile and then shook his hand after the swearing-in. Eisenhower, a war hero and one of the most successful presidents in American history, was seventy at the time. But he was not the oldest man in attendance. To greet the new president and pass the torch of